another as well. Thus a feedback loop existed in which their ties to one another reinforced the interconnectedness of the three loci in which they were active, while activity in each of these loci simultaneously compounded the relations among the groups.

Lashkar was part of the same jihadi galaxy as these other groups, but it moved in a separate orbit. Unlike the Deobandi groups whose cadres trained in Taliban-controlled territory from the mid-1990s onwards, Lashkar continued to use Kunar province as its primary Afghan training base after the Taliban came to power. The Afghan Salafis based there were antithetical to the Deobandi Taliban, which never invested too much effort in gaining control of the province.[97] Lashkar shared this sentiment and its cadres typically did not fight alongside the Taliban in Afghanistan, though contact between the two did occur. According to Noman Benotman, a former leader of the Libyan Islamic Fighting Group who worked with Lashkar during its early years, its members were only comfortable with other Salafis and viewed most Afghans as mushrikun[98]—the term used to denote those who commit shirk, which means polytheism, idolatry or the association of others with God. Salafis use the term against those Muslims who do not follow the Salafi creed.[99] Lashkar members felt similarly about many Muslims in Pakistan, especially Barelvi and Shia Muslims, and occasionally dabbled in sectarian violence against them as the next chapter will detail. These activities generally ceased after the group became the ISI's favored proxy for the Kashmir jihad in the early-to-mid 1990s. Thus, during the latter years of the decade when all of the Deobandi groups were increasing their ties to one another as well as to the Taliban and some of them were involved in sectarian violence in Pakistan, Lashkar was focused overwhelmingly on waging jihad in Indian-administered Kashmir. This meant it was a group apart within the jihadi milieu in terms of both its sectarian identity and its operations.